

you and your girlfriend, all available for the viewing pleasure of some nameless government or corporate agent.

Like we said, this tale about online privacy is not a happy one, not even a hopeful one. If you started out reading this story thinking that we would be able to share some amazing solutions with you that would help erase your worries, then we're sorry to disappoint. However, through this story, our attempt will be to bring you up to speed on how your online privacy is being infringed upon and which are the major parties involved in the process. In the story that follows, Anirudh will also share tools you can use and best practices

at 29 years, 11 months and 24 days, he was branded a "defector" and a "traitor" by the United States government and charged as a spy. Today, a mere five months later, Snowden's name is synonymous with the now commonplace news on online spying and privacy infringements that both the US and other governments are actively engaged in.

In May of this year, Snowden who was working with Booz Allen Hamilton, a defence firm sub-contracted by the NSA (National Security Agency), in Hawaii, flew to Hong Kong with data pertaining to the U.S. government's mass surveillance programs. In Hong Kong, Snowden got



The eye in the sky

tion tools being used by the intelligence community. However, there's no denying the fact that PRISM is actually a very powerful tool within the scope of its functionality and makes the job of analysing collected data a whole lot easier for all the people concerned.

Apart from PRISM, Snowden also revealed the existence of programs such as XKEYSCORE and TEMPORA that were part of a global surveillance program conducted by not only the US but also its allies that included the UK, Canada, Australia and New Zealand. Through a concerted effort, these countries are keeping tabs on India and other nations like China, Iran, Pakistan, Russia, France, Brazil, Japan, Germany and Afghanistan (some of which have their own surveillance presence on the Web) primarily using data gleaned online.

Perhaps more shocking were the media's claims about how most of the technology companies that have become a part of our daily lives (think Google, Facebook, Yahoo, Microsoft) were in bed with the NSA and the various governments of the countries they were operating in. These reports also accused the companies of giving security agencies 'backdoor' access to their servers. These accusations have turned out to be somewhat inaccurate (unless the company's name happens to be 'Verizon' or is another U.S. telecom operator) and we'll talk about these allegations in the next section of the story.

The Orwellian Internet

As the scope and reach of the Internet has widened, we've become more and more comfortable with the idea of storing our personal and private information online. This is because we do implicitly and explicitly trust the services that we use online, at least to a certain extent. For instance, you wouldn't think twice before

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you can follow to make sure you're doing all you can to protect your privacy the next time you're on the Internet.

Snowden: The Man Who Opened the Floodgates

Edward Snowden, 30, is an unassuming looking man with the appearance of a stereotypical IT professional. A pair of slim glasses frame his face and only add to this picture of someone who could be described using generic, bland terms such as 'normal' or 'average'. Despite this regular-Joe image that Snowden projects,

in touch with The Guardian, a UK based newspaper and proceeded to leak critical data that painted the entire picture of how massive the surveillance undertaking actually is.

One of the most important revelations was regarding something called 'PRISM' that has been incorrectly branded as THE tool being used by the NSA to keep track of the Internet. 'PRISM' is actually something like a customized interface that NSA and other American intelligence analysts use to collate and view data collected by the various data scraping and accumula-



A video still of Edward Snowden talking to the Guardian